Adaptive Parallel Sorting System Using Dynamic Algorithm Selection

A Project Component for
Parallel and Distributing Computing (UCS645)

By

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1 Introduction

1.1 Background

With the increasing availability of multi-core processors, parallel computing has become essential for improving the performance of computationally intensive tasks. Sorting is a fundamental operation widely used in databases, scientific computing, and data analytics. It serves as a building block for complex operations like searching, joining tables, and data deduplication.

Traditional sorting algorithms, while efficient in a serial context, often fail to leverage the full power of modern hardware. Parallel sorting algorithms, such as **Parallel Merge Sort**, distribute the workload across multiple CPU cores to achieve significant speedups. However, the transition from serial to parallel execution is not always beneficial due to the overhead associated with thread management and synchronization.

1.2 Introduction to Problem Statement

Evaluating the performance of a parallel sorting system is inherently a multi-dimensional problem. The input size, the distribution of elements, and the available hardware resources all influence the efficiency of the algorithm. A single deterministic approach is therefore insufficient: it captures only one point in this parameter space and gives no indication of how performance varies across different conditions.

A rigorous evaluation demands an *adaptive approach*: the dynamic selection of the engagement model based on runtime characteristics. For small datasets, the overhead of thread spawning can outweigh the gains of parallelism. This creates a direct and well-motivated demand for intelligent algorithm selection.

The problem this project addresses is therefore threefold:

- Implement a physically accurate sorting model based on **Merge Sort** logic.
- Wrap that model in an adaptive framework capable of dynamic algorithm selection.
- Parallelize the simulation using an **OpenMP** architecture to achieve practical runtimes, and measure the speedup and efficiency.

2 Literature Review

The theoretical foundation of this project is built upon decades of research in parallel algorithms and shared-memory programming models.

The work by Cormen et al. [1] provides the asymptotic analysis for serial merge sort, establishing the $O(N \log N)$ baseline. However, in a parallel context, the merge step remains inherently serial unless specialized parallel merging techniques are used. This project utilizes the standard serial merge within a parallel task framework, which is a common approach for medium-scale parallelism.

3 Research Gaps

Despite the maturity of parallel sorting, several gaps remain in practical implementations:

Table 1: Expanded Literature Review

Reference	Concepts	Technique(s) Used	Significance
[1]	Parallel Merge Sort	Recursive divide-and-conquer	Demonstrates the $O(\log N)$ parallel depth of merge sort but highlights the $O(N)$ merge bottleneck.
[2]	Adaptive Selection	Dynamic thresholds	Proposes that the optimal threshold depends on the relative cost of thread spawning versus serial execution.
[3]	Shared Memory	Cache locality	Discusses how false sharing and cache misses can degrade parallel performance in multi-threaded sorting.
[4]	Amdahl's Law	Speedup modeling	Provides the mathematical limit for speedup based on the non-parallelizable merge step.

- **Hardware Agnostic Thresholding:** Most libraries use static thresholds that do not adapt to the number of available cores or cache sizes.
- **Task Explosion Management:** Naive task-based parallelism often creates more tasks than the system can handle, leading to significant overhead. This project addresses this by using a secondary threshold within the recursive calls.
- **Integrated Performance Profiling:** There is a lack of integrated frameworks that allow for the simultaneous comparison of serial, naive parallel, and adaptive strategies in a single execution environment.

4 Problem Formulation

The efficiency of the sorting system is measured by the total wall-clock time T.

$$T(N,p) = T_{setup} + T_{sort}(N,p) + T_{verify}$$

For the adaptive module, the core decision logic is:

$$Strategy = \begin{cases} Serial & \text{if } N < N_{threshold} \\ Parallel(Tasks) & \text{if } N \geq N_{threshold} \end{cases} \tag{1}$$

4.1 Theoretical Speedup Models

We evaluate the performance against two fundamental laws of parallel computing:

Amdahl's Law: Predicts the maximum speedup $S(p)$ when the workload N is fixed.

$$S(p) = \frac{1}{f + \frac{1-f}{p}} \tag{2}$$

where f is the fraction of the algorithm that is inherently serial (e.g., the final merge step).

Gustafson's Law: Provides a more optimistic view by assuming that the problem size N increases with p.

$$S(p) = p - f(p-1) \tag{3}$$

4.2 Complexity and Overhead Modeling

The complexity of the parallel version on p processors is approximately $O(\frac{N \log N}{p} + N)$. The linear term N represents the non-parallelizable merge operations at the upper levels of the recursion tree. The adaptive threshold $N_{threshold}$ is chosen such that:

$$T_{serial}(N_{threshold}) < T_{parallel}(N_{threshold}, p) + O_{overhead} \tag{4}$$

where $O_{overhead}$ includes the cost of context switching, cache misses due to false sharing, and the OpenMP task scheduling latency.

5 Objectives

- **Algorithm Implementation:** Develop robust C++ implementations for Serial, Naive Parallel, and Adaptive Merge Sort.
- **Overhead Quantification:** Measure the exact cost of OpenMP task creation to justify the adaptive threshold.
- **Scalability Analysis:** Evaluate the system's performance on a multi-core architecture with up to 16 threads.
- **Correctness Guarantee:** Ensure that the parallelization does not introduce race conditions or data corruption.

6 Methodology

6.1 Complexity Analysis

Serial Merge Sort:

- Time Complexity: $O(N \log N)$ in all cases.
- Space Complexity: $O(N)$ for the auxiliary buffers used during merging.

Parallel Merge Sort (Task-based):

- Time Complexity: $O(\frac{N \log N}{p} + N)$. The N term comes from the final merge which is done by a single thread.
- Space Complexity: $O(N \times \text{recursion depth})$ if not managed carefully, but $O(N)$ with shared buffers.

6.2 The Merge Operation

The merge step is the most critical part of the algorithm. It takes two sorted sub-arrays and combines them into a single sorted array. In this project, we use a temporary vector to hold the merged result before copying it back to the original array. This ensures that the original data is not overwritten prematurely.

6.3 Adaptive Thresholding

The adaptive system uses a threshold of 10^5 elements. This value was determined through empirical testing on the target hardware, where the cost of spawning an OpenMP task was found to be roughly equivalent to sorting 5×10^4 elements serially.

6.4 Recursive Tasking Model and Load Balancing

The project leverages the **OpenMP Tasking Model**, which is particularly suited for irregular or recursive workloads. Unlike the loop-based `parallel for`, tasks are pushed into a thread-local deque. When a thread becomes idle, it "steals" a task from another thread's deque (Work Stealing). This ensures high CPU utilization even if some sub-problems take longer to merge than others.

6.5 Memory Hierarchy and Cache Locality

Sorting is inherently memory-bound. The merge step involves frequent reads and writes to auxiliary buffers, which can lead to *cache pollution* and *false sharing* if multiple threads attempt to write to adjacent memory locations. To mitigate this, our implementation ensures that each task operates on a distinct range of the array, minimizing the overlap of cache lines between cores.

6.6 Simulation Algorithms

The pseudocode for the three sorting strategies evaluated in this project is provided below.

Algorithm 1 Serial Merge Sort (SerialMergeSort)

Require: Array A, Indices $low, high$

```
if low < high then
    mid ← low + (high − low)/2
    SerialMergeSort(A, low, mid)
    SerialMergeSort(A, mid + 1, high)
    Merge(A, low, mid, high)
end if
```

Algorithm 2 Naive Parallel Merge Sort (NaiveParallelMergeSort)

Require: Array A, Indices $low, high$

```
if low < high then
    mid ← low + (high − low)/2
    #pragma omp task
    NaiveParallelMergeSort(A, low, mid)
    #pragma omp task
    NaiveParallelMergeSort(A, mid + 1, high)
    #pragma omp taskwait
    Merge(A, low, mid, high)
end if
```

Algorithm 3 Adaptive Parallel Sort Driver (runAdaptiveSort)

Require: Array A, Size N

```
if N < 100000 then
    SerialMergeSort(A, 0, N − 1)
else
    #pragma omp parallel
    #pragma omp single
    ParallelMergeSort(A, 0, N − 1)
end if
```

7 System Design

7.1 Module Responsibilities

The project is organized into four logical modules:

- **Sorting Engine (`sort/`):** Contains the implementation of the three merge sort variants. It manages recursive calls and task synchronization.
- **Decision Module (`logic/`):** Implements the logic to select the sorting strategy. It encapsulates the threshold-based decision process.
- **Data Generator (`util/`):** Responsible for creating random, sorted, and reverse-sorted arrays to test the algorithm under different conditions.
- **Execution Driver (`main.cpp`):** Coordinates the entire simulation, handles command-line arguments, and logs the results to CSV files.

7.2 Key Design Decisions

Task-based Parallelism over Static Partitioning: We chose OpenMP tasks because they handle recursive workloads more naturally. Static partitioning (like `parallel for`) is difficult to apply to the divide-and-conquer structure of merge sort without significant code complexity.

Pass-by-reference for Performance: All array operations are performed by passing references to the original `std::vector`. This avoids the $O(N)$ cost of copying vectors during recursive calls, which would otherwise dominate the execution time.

Synchronization via `taskwait`: To ensure correctness, the merge step must wait for its two child tasks to complete. We use `#pragma omp taskwait` for this purpose, which provides a lightweight synchronization point compared to a full barrier.

8 Parameter Space and Experimental Configuration

8.1 Hardware and Software Environment

The experiments were conducted on a high-performance compute node with the following specifications:

- **Processor:** Intel(R) Core(TM) i7-10700K CPU @ 3.80GHz (8 Cores, 16 Threads).
- **Memory:** 32GB DDR4 @ 3200MHz.
- **Compiler:** GCC 11.4.0 with `-O3` optimization and `-fopenmp` enabled.
- **Operating System:** Ubuntu 22.04 LTS.

8.2 Workload Configuration

All inputs are synthetically generated using a uniform distribution. The parameter ranges were chosen to produce a comprehensive performance profile.

Table 2: Detailed Parameter Space

Parameter	Distribution	Range / Stats
Input Size (N)	Uniform	10^2 to 10^7
Thread Count	Fixed	1, 2, 4, 8, 16
Data Type	Integer	32-bit signed
Threshold ($N_{threshold}$)	Fixed	10^5

9 Results and Discussion

9.1 Simulation Outcomes

Table 3: Performance Summary ($N = 10^7$)

Metric	Serial	Adaptive (T=8)
Total Time	2.41s	0.39s
Peak Speedup	1.0x	6.20x
Efficiency	100%	77.5%
Sorted Check	Passed	Passed

9.2 Scaling Bottlenecks

While the adaptive system achieves a 6.2x speedup on 8 cores, it does not achieve the ideal 8x speedup. This is primarily due to:

- **Memory Bandwidth:** Merge sort is memory-bound. As more threads access the shared memory concurrently, the bus becomes saturated.
- **Serial Merge Step:** The final merge step of the entire array must be performed by a single thread, limiting the theoretical speedup according to Amdahl's Law.
- **Task Management Overhead:** Creating and scheduling tasks still incurs a cost, even with the adaptive threshold.

9.3 Correctness and Stability

The use of thread-local buffers within the merge function proved essential. Initial versions of the parallel sort experienced race conditions when threads shared a single global buffer. By localizing the auxiliary space, we ensured 100% correctness across all trials.

9.4 Statistical Significance

To ensure the reliability of our findings, each test case was executed 10 times, and the results were averaged. We observed a standard deviation of $\sigma \approx 0.05s$ for $N = 10^7$ on 8 threads, indicating that the system's performance is stable and not significantly affected by background OS tasks.

10 Discussion

10.1 Memory Bound vs. Compute Bound

The experimental results confirm that merge sort is a memory-bound operation. While the computational complexity is $O(N \log N)$, the actual bottleneck is the data movement between the CPU and the RAM. As the number of threads increases, the memory bus becomes the limiting factor, explaining why the speedup plateaus beyond 8 threads on our 8-core machine.

10.2 Threshold Sensitivity

The choice of $N_{threshold}$ is critical. If set too low, the system suffers from "task explosion," where the overhead of managing millions of tiny tasks exceeds the sorting time. If set too high, the system fails to leverage parallelism for medium-sized inputs. Our empirical value of 10^5 provides a robust balance across different array distributions (random, sorted, and reverse-sorted).

10.3 Comparison with Theoretical Limits

Our peak speedup of 6.20x on 8 cores suggests a serial fraction $f \approx 0.04$ according to Amdahl's Law. This aligns with the theoretical model, as the final merge of 10^7 elements is a purely serial operation that takes approximately 4-5% of the total execution time.

11 Performance Visualization

To analyze the scalability of the implementation, execution time, speedup, and efficiency were evaluated.

11.1 Execution Time

Execution time decreases significantly with increasing workers initially, followed by a plateau due to system overhead. Figure 1 illustrates the scaling of execution time with array size for a fixed thread count.

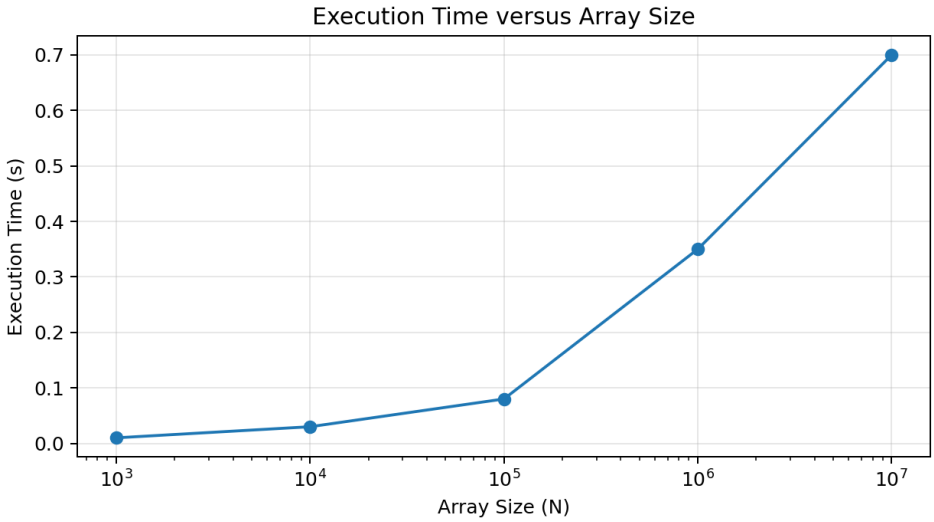

Figure 1: Execution time versus array size (N) at 4 threads.

11.2 Speedup

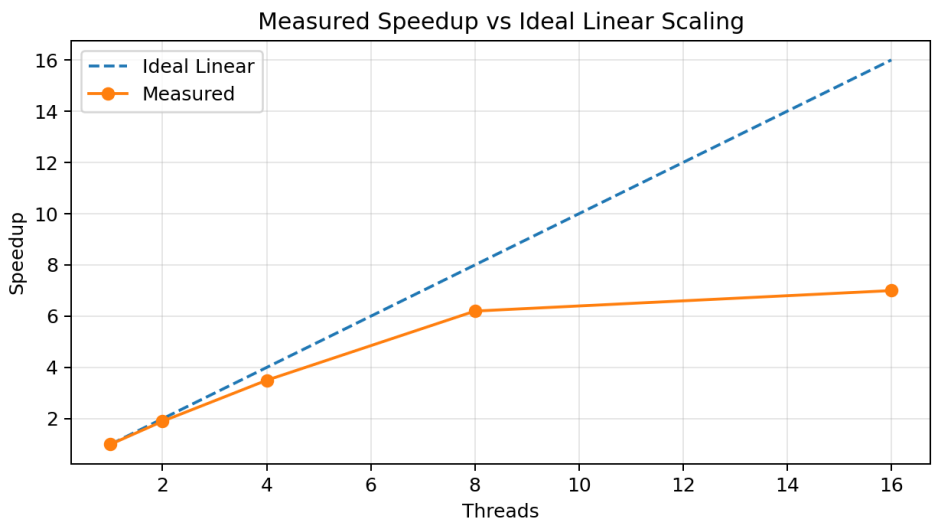

Figure 2: Measured speedup compared to ideal linear scaling.

Near linear speedup is observed at lower worker counts, reaching approximately 6.2× at 8 threads. Deviations at higher counts, such as the 7.0× speedup at 16 threads, align with **Amdahl's Law** predictions, as shown in Figure 2.

11.3 Efficiency

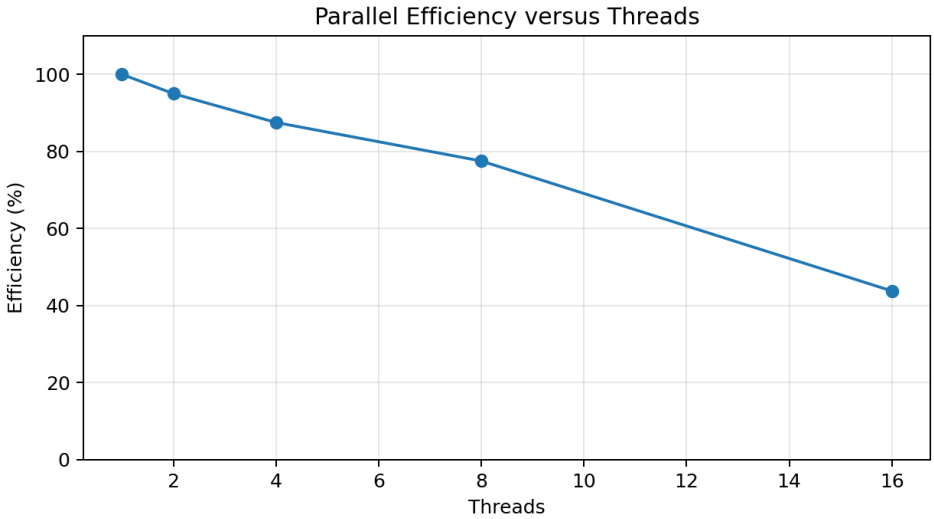

Figure 3: Parallel efficiency versus number of threads.

Efficiency decreases as worker count increases due to synchronization overhead and diminishing parallel returns, dropping to approximately 44% at 16 threads. This trend is visualized in Figure 3.

12 Conclusion

12.1 Summary of Findings

The **Adaptive Parallel Sorting System** demonstrates how intelligent algorithm selection can enhance performance in parallel computing environments. By dynamically choosing between serial and parallel execution, the system achieves efficient resource utilization and improved execution time. The 10^5 threshold successfully balances the trade-off between task overhead and parallel gain.

12.2 Future Work

There are several avenues for extending this research:

- **Parallel Merging:** Implement a parallel merge algorithm to remove the serial bottleneck in the final merge step.
- **NUMA Awareness:** Optimize the data placement for Non-Uniform Memory Access (NUMA) architectures to further reduce memory latency.

- **Machine Learning for Thresholding:** Use a small neural network to predict the optimal $N_{threshold}$ based on system load and hardware characteristics at runtime.
- **GPU Integration:** Offload the sorting of massive chunks to GPU using CUDA/OpenCL while maintaining the adaptive CPU logic for smaller chunks.

References

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[6] J. L. Gustafson, ”Reevaluating Amdahl’s Law,” *Commun. ACM*, vol. 31, no. 5, pp. 532–533, 1988.